POSC 3710: European Politics

10/28/2026: THE OTHER CHALLENGERS: GREENS, REGIONALISTS, AND THE RADICAL LEFT

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Who is this?



Alexis Tsipras, prime minister of Greece, 2015–19. His radical left party, Syriza, won 36% of the vote in January 2015.

By 2023 it was down to 18%. Tsipras resigned as leader, left parliament in 2025, and launched a new party in May 2026.

Where We Left Off

- A new unit: challengers and cleavages
- Just wrapped: the mainstream families, and party systems built on class and religion
- Since the 1970s the big parties have been losing voters
- Today: the first wave of challenges, mostly on the left
- Next: the radical right

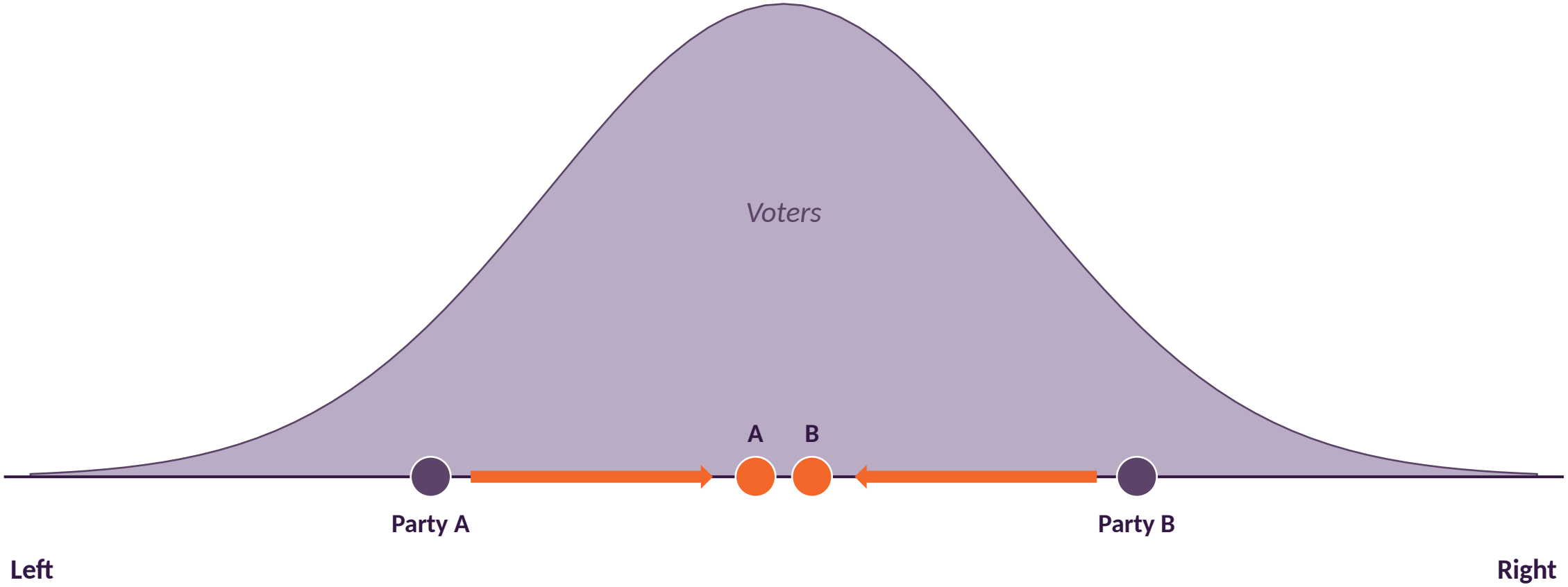
Challenger Parties

- Mainstream parties: the long-standing, office-seeking parties in most European party systems
- Challengers have come in waves over the last 30 to 40 years
  - Some became established; others disappeared
- Greens, new-left parties, anti-tax parties, radical centrists, regional parties, pirate parties…
- Is it what the parties supply, or what voters demand?

Downs: Spatial Models of Politics

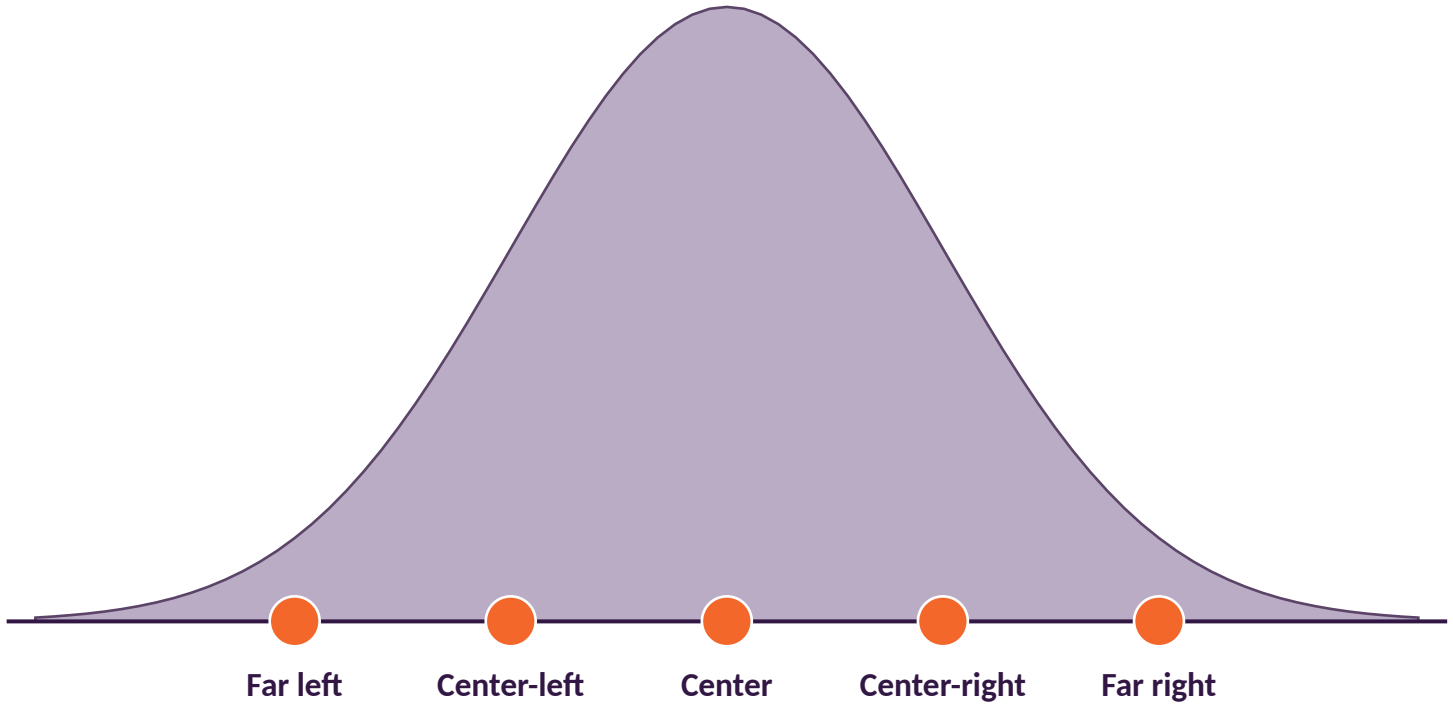
- Anthony Downs, an American economist, 1957: a model of where shops locate on a street, applied to parties
- The simplest version:
  - Two parties, one dimension from left to right
  - Most voters near the middle: think of a bell curve
  - Each voter picks the closest party
- How should the two parties position themselves? Why?

Two parties. Where should each one stand?



Each party gains votes by moving toward the other, until they meet at the median voter. Neither can do better by moving away.

With more parties, where should each one stand?



Extra parties can differentiate themselves and pick up voters far from the middle

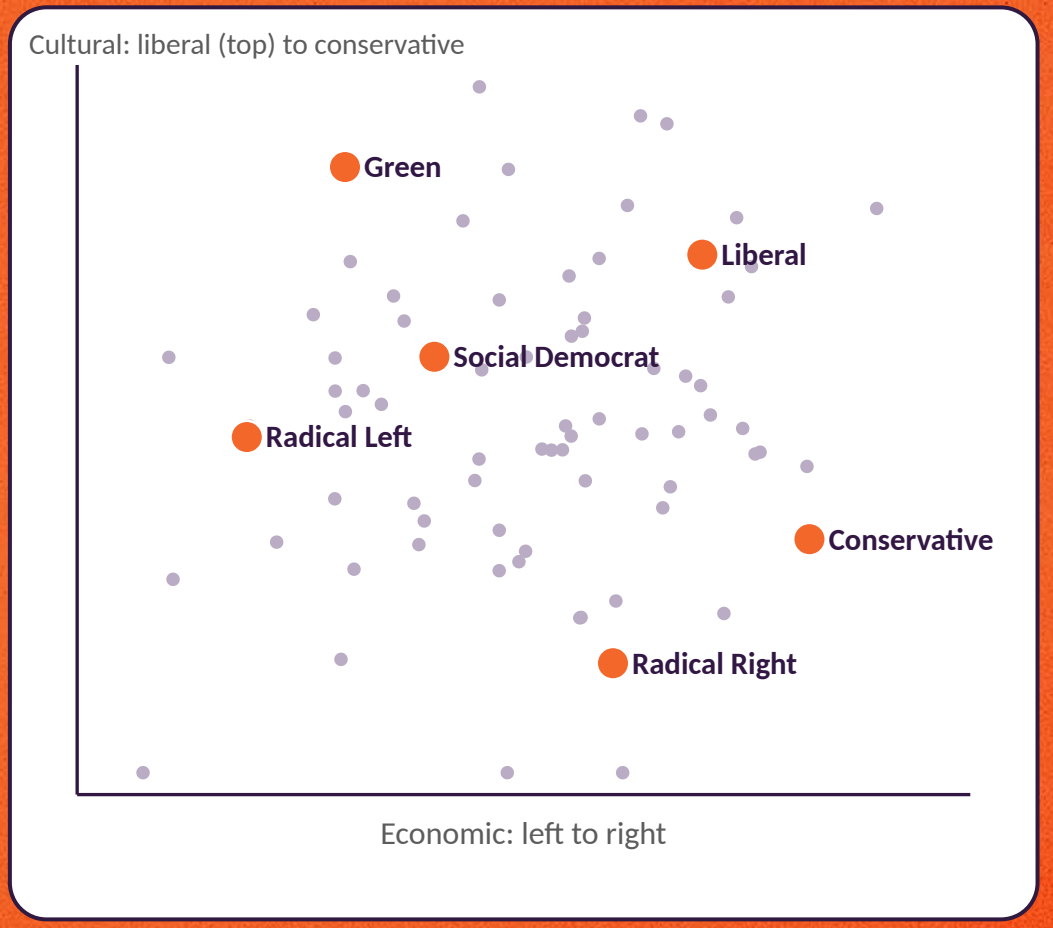
Parties in the middle should still do well: that is where most voters are

No clear equilibrium, so less stability than in a two-party system

What might complicate this?

Multiple Dimensions

- What if voters care about more than one dimension, and the two are not closely related?
  - To Americans these preferences can look “incoherent”
- A party can be anti-immigrant, but also pro-union and pro-environment
- Or for small government and low taxes, but also socially liberal
- Then no position is safe: party systems should change more from election to election



Post-Materialist Values



Ronald Inglehart

- Ronald Inglehart, an American political scientist: as societies grow richer, priorities change
- From material concerns (economic security, law and order) to post-materialist values (the environment, human rights, personal autonomy)
- The shift first fed the Greens and other progressive challengers, among younger, educated voters
- Later it also fed the populist right

Elections as a marketplace of ideas: supply and demand

SUPPLY

Parties offer

- Parties supply packages of issue positions, and persuade voters that those issues matter
- Niche parties can be “issue entrepreneurs”

DEMAND

Voters ask

- Voters want certain policies, and parties adjust their positions to match
- The Greens: voters’ concern, or the party’s campaign?

If the existing parties can’t or won’t reposition, new parties emerge

From today's reading: Meguid

Meguid: What Makes Niche Parties Different?

- Bonnie Meguid, an American political scientist, 2005
- They reject the class-based orientation of politics
- Their issues cut across the old lines of division
- They stick to a narrow set of issues
  - What is the Green Party's foreign policy? The populist right's economic philosophy?



A sign from Andrew Yang's 2020 campaign for the Democratic presidential nomination. Note, I met the head of Forward party at an electoral reform event – interesting guy!

You run the big party of the center-left. What do you do?

A new Green party has just won 6% of the vote by campaigning on one issue, the environment. Most of its voters used to be yours.

A

Ignore it

Say nothing about the environment. Treat the new party as a fad.

DISMISSIVE

B

Copy it

Adopt its position on the environment as your own.

ACCOMMODATIVE

C

Attack it

Take the opposite position, and say so loudly.

ADVERSARIAL

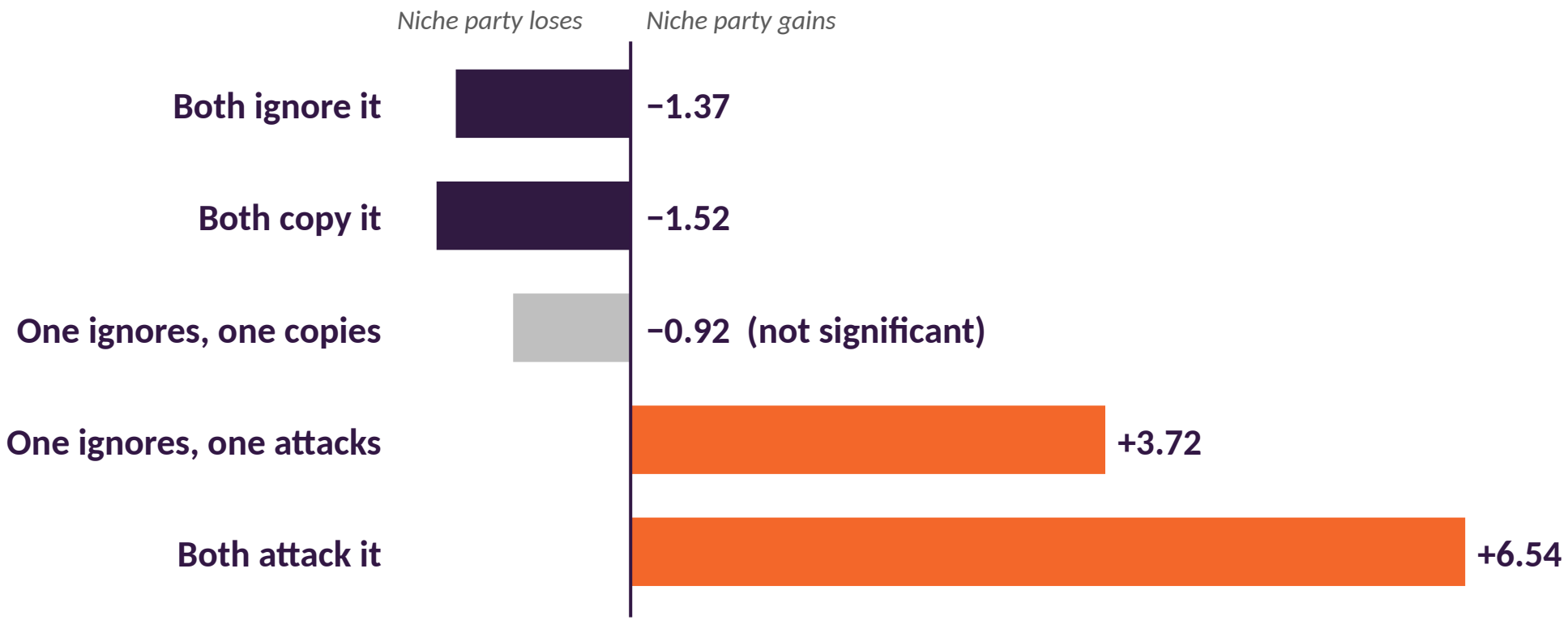
Now you run the big party of the center-right. The Greens are taking votes from your rival, and almost none from you. What do you do?

What each strategy does to the niche party

	DISMISSIVE: IGNORE	ACCOMMODATIVE: COPY	ADVERSARIAL: ATTACK
How much the issue matters to voters	Falls	Rises	Rises
Who owns the issue	No effect	Moves to the mainstream party	Stays with the niche party
The niche party's vote	**Falls**	**Falls**	**Rises**

Note – this is Meguid's theory. The accommodative strategy assumes that voters find the mainstream party credible on the issue. This might not always be true!

Meguid's Results



Percentage points of the vote. Green and radical right parties in 17 Western European countries, 1970–2000. If one party copies and the other attacks, the more forceful of the two wins out.

This data is old. Someone should write a follow up paper!

From today's reading: Meguid

France: The Socialists and the National Front

- Socialist party attacked the National Front (FN) early. That strengthened the Front at the expense of the Gaullist right
- 1986: the Socialists switched to proportional representation, and the Front won 35 seats
  - Then they switched back because the right wanted to block the FN
- The right only moved towards FN on immigration after they had already become a strong party



Marine Le Pen, who led the National Front from 2011; it is now the National Rally. In the 1980s the leader was her father, Jean-Marie Le Pen

Origins of Green Parties

- Green parties grew out of the ecological and anti-nuclear movements of the 1960s and 70s
  - First national green party: New Zealand, 1972. Germany's Greens: 1980
- At first often anti-capitalist, anarchist and pacifist
- By the 1990s: more mainstream positions, middle-class and educated voters, a narrower focus
- As concern over climate change grew, Greens entered coalition governments across Europe



Petra Kelly, a founder of the German Greens ("Neither left nor right, but in front")

Green Parties



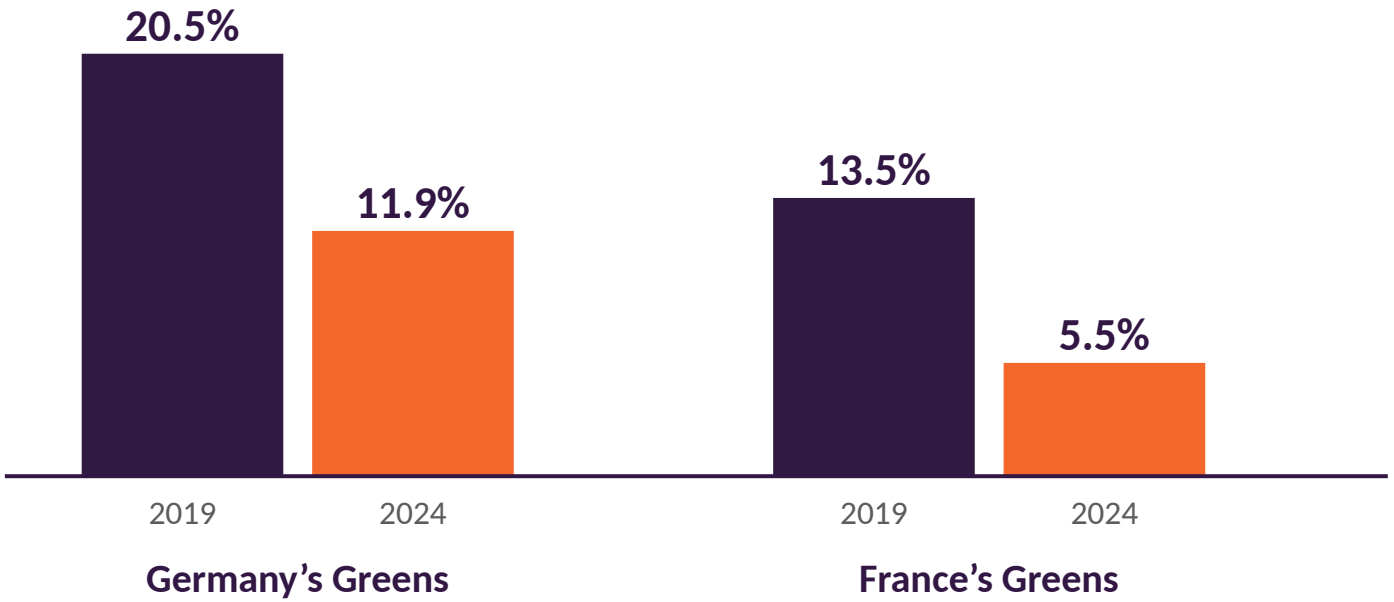
Annalena Baerbock of the Greens, Germany's foreign minister, 2021–25

- Climate is still the key issue: a "Green New Deal," 100% renewable energy, often opposed to nuclear power
- Social policy: progressive, often explicitly feminist and pro-multicultural
- Economic policy: "green capitalism." Pro-market, with environmental regulation
- Foreign policy: ????

GUESS THE NUMBER

The Greens' group won 74 seats in the European Parliament in 2019. How many in 2024?

A	B	C	D
91	74	67	53



In between, the Greens got what they asked for:

the European Green Deal

A law binding the EU to net-zero emissions by 2050

Share of the vote in each country's European Parliament election. The Parliament had 751 seats in 2019 and 720 in 2024; after Britain left, the Greens' group held 67.

What the Greens said about climate: 2019 and 2024

2019: "PITCH PERFECT"

Two messages

- Strategies for the climate and energy transition
- The opportunities the transition would bring

2024: "EPIC FAIL"

Four messages

- Repeated the promises of 2019
- Technical issues that are hard to grasp
- Criticized the Green Deal
- Shifted attention to other initiatives

Sergiu Gherghina, a political scientist at the University of Glasgow: the manifestos of 16 Green parties in 13 countries. They said more about climate in 2024 (113 statements, up from 73). How much a party said had no relation to the seats it won or lost.

From today's readings: Meguid and Gherghina

Won the Debate, Lost the Election

- The Green Deal was the program of Ursula von der Leyen, president of the European Commission and a German Christian democrat
- Meguid: when a big party copies the issue, ownership moves to it
- The Greens' problem in 2024: claim the Deal and sound like the establishment, or criticize it and disown their own success
- In 2025 the Greens left government in Ireland, Belgium, Austria and Germany



Ursula von der Leyen at the EUs presentation of the Green Deal

Populist and Radical Left Parties



Jean-Luc Mélenchon, founder of France Unbowed: 22% for president in 2022

- Often grew out of Marxist or communist movements
- Discredited during the Cold War, except in France and Italy
- Reborn after the USSR fell, and became more popular after the 2008 financial crisis
  - A backlash against austerity and “third way” social democrats
- Success varies: Syriza governed Greece; France Unbowed is the largest party of the French left; Spain’s Podemos faded

From today's reading: Rooduijn et al.

Radical left voter, radical right voter, or both?

"The economy is in bad shape."	Has a university degree	"Immigration is a threat."
BOTH	RADICAL LEFT	RADICAL RIGHT
"European unification has gone too far."	"The government should reduce differences in income."	Working class, with a low income
BOTH	RADICAL LEFT	BOTH

European Social Survey, 2002–2014: voters for 23 radical left and 26 radical right parties in 23 countries, compared with mainstream voters.

Regional Parties



Nicola Sturgeon of the Scottish National Party, first minister of Scotland, 2014–23

- Tied to regions that are distinct economically, culturally or linguistically
- Belgium has regional party systems instead of regional parties!
- Historically not very successful in Western Europe as electoral vehicles
  - In Northern Ireland and the Basque Country, some nationalists took up arms instead
- In recent years, some have done very well

Which of these is not led by a regionalist or nationalist party today?

A
Scotland

B
Wales

C
Belgium

D
Catalonia

SCOTLAND

The Scottish National Party won its fifth election in a row in May 2026: 58 of 129 seats. John Swinney is first minister.

WALES



Plaid Cymru came first in May 2026, with 43 of 96 seats. Its leader, Rhun ap Iorwerth, is first minister. Labour fell to 9.

BELGIUM



Bart De Wever, a Flemish nationalist, has been prime minister of the whole country since February 2025.

CATALONIA



The pro-independence parties lost their majority in 2024. Salvador Illa, a Socialist, leads the regional government.

At Westminster the Scottish National Party went from 56 of Scotland's 59 seats in 2015 to 9 of 57 in 2024.

Some other parties

Pirate Party
Czech Republic

Began with file sharing and internet freedom

SEATS

18 seats in 2025; in government 2021–24

Party for the Animals
Netherlands

Animal rights first

SEATS

3 of 150 seats in 2025

50PLUS
Netherlands

A party for pensioners

SEATS

2 seats in 2025

Farmer–Citizen Movement
Netherlands

Founded in 2019 against limits on farming

SEATS

First in the 2023 provincial elections; then in government

Beer Party
Austria

Founded by a punk rock singer

NO SEATS

2.0% in 2024; the threshold is 4%

Two-Tailed Dog Party
Hungary

A joke party

NO SEATS

None in April 2026

Die PARTEI
Germany

Founded by the editors of a satirical magazine

SEATS

2 in the European Parliament since 2019

Automobile Party
Switzerland

Founded in 1985 to defend drivers

SEATS

8 seats in 1991

Key Points

- European party systems leave room for many more parties, and so for more issues and combinations of issues
- New parties respond to what voters demand, and also act as “issue entrepreneurs”
- How a new party fares depends in large part on how the big parties respond to it
- New issues do not automatically map onto the old divisions